TDRA Board Renews Telecom Licences of Both Operators for Another 20 Years From Connectivity Leadership to AI Leadership... A New Era for Digital Infrastructure and the Digital Economy

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The Board of Directors of the Telecommunications and Digital Government Regulatory Authority (TDRA) has announced the renewal of the Public Telecommunications Licences of Emirates Telecommunications Group Company PJSC (e&) and Emirates Integrated Telecommunications Company PJSC (du) for another 20 years, based on the Federal Decree-Law on the Regulation of the Telecommunications Sector, as amended.

The renewed licenses will be effective from 9 August 2026 until 8 August 2046, replacing the licences issued in 2006. The renewal provides the sector with a long-term regulatory framework that offers the stability required to sustain investment in digital infrastructure and future technologies.

Two Decades of Achievement

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Over the past two decades, the telecommunications sector has evolved from providing traditional services into a strategic enabler of digital transformation, government services and smart cities. The UAE has maintained its global leadership in household fibre-optic network penetration according to the latest international indicators, ranking first globally for the tenth consecutive year, with a penetration rate of 99.7%.

Infrastructure for the National Economy

H.E. Talal Belhoul, Chairman of TDRA, said: "The infrastructure of the national economy relies on telecommunications networks across all vital sectors, including government services, financial services, healthcare, education, energy, transport, industry and digital commerce. The next phase takes on added importance in light of the Digital Economy Strategy, which aims to double the digital economy's contribution to GDP from 9.7% in 2022 to 19.4% over the next ten years."The sector is also expected to gradually transition from connected networks to intelligent, autonomous networks, where artificial intelligence becomes an integral part of the intelligence of the network itself."

A Long-Term Framework for the Sector

H.E. Eng. Majed Sultan Al Mesmar, Director General of TDRA, said: "The renewal of the two licences is a strategic decision that reflects the UAE's confidence in a sector that has proven to be one of the pillars of national development. Together, TDRA and the licensees have built one of the world's most advanced and future-ready digital infrastructures.

"Today, we are providing the sector with a long-term framework that lays the foundation for a new phase in which connectivity evolves into intelligence, and digital infrastructure becomes a national platform for innovation and sustainable growth."

H.E. Eng. Mohammed Al Ramsi, Deputy Director General of the Telecommunications Sector at TDRA, said: "The new licences reflect the transformation of telecommunications networks into critical national infrastructure. They require licensees to geographically diversify international connectivity through multiple terrestrial systems and submarine cables, eliminate single points of failure, implement disaster recovery mechanisms and test them regularly, and develop qualified national talent capable of operating and restoring networks under exceptional circumstances.

"Today, the objective goes beyond developing a faster network to building a smarter, more secure and more resilient one. The two licences include an enhanced set of obligations, most notably a comprehensive framework covering network resilience, backup capacity and international connectivity, in addition to quality of service, interconnection and access, national roaming, universal service, subscriber protection and the prevention of anti-competitive practices."

A Strong Regulatory Partnership

The renewal reflects the depth of the partnership between TDRA and the two licensees, based on transparency and commitment to the regulatory framework. TDRA will continue to monitor compliance with the licence conditions, ensure a fair and competitive environment, protect subscriber rights and enhance service quality across the UAE.

While the past twenty years have reinforced the UAE's position at the forefront of global digital infrastructure and connectivity, the next twenty years aim to take the country from connectivity leadership to AI leadership, and from building networks to building the economy of the future.

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